17. Xi Jinping’s China Dream and the Community of Common Destiny

In the previous chapter, we traced the trajectory of China’s economic transformation and the factors that accounted for its remarkable success. Spanning a little more than four decades, from 1978 to the present, this was a period during which the geopolitics of Asia and the world also witnessed dramatic changes. This changing geopolitical landscape offered China opportunities that could be leveraged to help it meet its economic goals. But China also witnessed periods of acute stress and being constrained by external influences which had to be navigated with care and caution.

The consistent and overriding objective of the CPC has always been regime survival and consolidation of the one-party Leninist state. Economic objectives were never allowed to undermine the political dominance of the Party. On the contrary, economic reforms and opening up were promoted precisely in order to ensure the survival of the CPC, whose legitimacy had been badly eroded during the extremely disruptive and chaotic ten-year Cultural Revolution.

In Chapter 15, we saw how India was held up as a ‘teacher by negative example’ in the rejuvenation of China sought by its key reformers during the early part of the twentieth century. During the waning years of the twentieth century, the swift collapse of the Soviet Union in 1990 and the disintegration of the world’s first ruling communist party, the CPSU, were also held up as a latter-day ‘teacher by negative example’ for the CPC. Chinese President Xi Jinping is said to have remarked that what kept him awake at night was the possible emergence of a Chinese Gorbachev leading to the collapse of the CPC.

How did Chinese leaders interpret the geopolitical changes occurring around them, and how did they adjust their economic strategies in response? And as China’s power continued to expand, how did it alter its